time it was different. They stood in two lines on both sides of the wicket with me in the middle, but as I started walking, players from the end of the lines kept running to the front in order to extend the guard of honour all the way to the boundary.

I could no longer hold back my tears. It was just too much. Such respect and affection was overwhelming and I will always remember the way my team-mates gave me my final send-off. By the time I walked off the ground I was openly crying. I could not look people in the eye and had to shake hands with the opposition players with my face turned to the ground. I did not want them to see me cry like a child. I did the same with our support staff and then just ran up the stairs to the dressing room and went straight to the bathroom.

That's where I broke down completely. I cried for about ten minutes until I finally told myself that enough was enough. I washed my face and came back to the dressing room with a towel over my head and sat in my seat completely alone. My team-mates had given me space and there was no one in the dressing room to disturb me. I looked at my kitbag and thanked my gear for being with me all my life.

I was gradually starting to come to terms with the moment when someone came in to say that Brian Lara and the West Indian team were waiting for me and that Brian had planned something special. It was rather unusual for an opposition team to do anything like that and it was very touching. My 200th Test was also Shivnarine Chanderpaul's 150th and Brian congratulated us on our achievements. Brian and I have been great friends and his words meant a lot to me. I then spoke briefly about Chanderpaul and the West Indian way of cricket before all the players took pictures with me.

I went back to the dressing room to get ready to walk out with the team for the presentations. Someone from Star Sports, the host broadcasters, came up to me and said that Ravi Shastri would ask me a few questions at the presentation, but I said I would rather speak by myself. I also said I would like to go on for a bit longer than usual, if they were agreeable, and suggested that it might be better if I was given the microphone after the players had collected their awards. They readily agreed and said I could go on for as long as I wanted, as they had all the time in the world for me!

A speech from the heart